

Perspectives

Character & Grammar Through Stories

Episode 5 – The Scholarship Decision

Level: B2–C1 (IELTS Band 7.0–8.0)

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Level: B2–C1

Learning Goals

- ✓ Read and interpret a dense, discursive, C1-level narrative
- ✓ Construct it-clefts and wh-clefts (what-clefts) for emphasis
- ✓ Use advanced linking devices: whereas, notwithstanding, provided that, in view of, on the grounds that
- ✓ Use the subjunctive mood in formal contexts (that + base verb / be)
- ✓ Acquire an extensive set of Academic Word List vocabulary and collocations
- ✓ Practise IELTS-style sentence transformation and error correction
- ✓ Produce an IELTS Task 2-style discursive paragraph
- ✓ Reflect critically on personal ambition, filial duty, and cultural expectation

SECTION 1 | WARM-UP — Before You Read

Part A — Prediction & Opinion Questions

Instructions: These questions require you to take a position, not just guess a plot. Answer before reading.

1. To what extent should personal ambition be subordinated to family responsibility, particularly in cultures where filial duty carries significant social and religious weight?

2. Some people argue that the expectations placed on daughters and sons within the same family are rarely symmetrical. To what extent do you agree, and what might account for this asymmetry?

Part B — Personal Reflection

Instructions: Answer honestly from your own experience or context.

1. Have you ever faced a decision in which what you wanted for yourself seemed to conflict with what your family expected of you? How did you navigate it?

2. In your own cultural or religious context, how is the balance between individual opportunity and family obligation typically understood?

SECTION 2 | MAIN STORY — Read the Story

Instructions: Read the story carefully. Underline every cleft sentence (it-cleft or wh-cleft), circle every advanced linking device, and box every subjunctive form.

The Scholarship Decision

For three days, the email had sat unopened in a folder Nusrat had labelled, half-jokingly, “Later.” She knew roughly what it contained; the subject line alone — Chevening Scholarship: Offer of Award — made that much clear. What she could not yet bring herself to face was everything the message would set in motion the moment she opened it.

It was her mother, not her father, who found her staring at the screen that evening and asked, simply, “Well?”

Nusrat exhaled. “I got it, Ammu. The scholarship. Full funding, London, starting in September.”

Her mother's face did something complicated — pride, undeniably, but something else beneath it that Nusrat recognised because she felt its mirror in herself. “Then why,” her mother asked, “do you look as though you've been handed bad news?”

“Because, in a sense, I have,” Nusrat said, and regretted at once how that sounded. “Not the scholarship itself. It was the thought of what leaving would actually mean — Abbu's knees, your blood pressure, Farhan already abroad, Rafi barely home before ten most nights — that undid me, not the flight or the paperwork.”

Whereas her brothers had left for work and marriage without a second thought ever being demanded of them, Nusrat had never quite escaped the quiet, unspoken assumption that she would be the one who stayed — not because anyone had ever said so outright, but because no one had ever needed to.

Her mother was silent for a long moment. “I won't pretend I haven't imagined what this house looks like without you in it,” she said eventually. “But I did not raise a daughter so that she could sit in this room, refusing a future out of guilt for a decision nobody actually asked her to make on our behalf. It is important that this choice be yours — made for the right reasons, not the easy ones.”

“And what would you call the right reasons?”

“That's not mine to hand you,” her mother said. “But I will say this: on the grounds that a daughter's place is at home — that's an argument I've heard my whole life, and I have never fully believed it. Provided that proper care is arranged for your father and me, and provided that you come back when it truly matters, I see no reason ambition and duty must cancel each other out.”

Nusrat sought a second opinion from Dr. Yasmin Akhtar, her undergraduate mentor, the following week — less for permission, she told herself, than for a kind of clarity she had not yet managed to reach alone. “What struck me most,” Nusrat admitted, “wasn't the scholarship at all. It was realising how much of my hesitation had nothing to do with my parents' actual wishes, and everything to do with what I assumed a good daughter was supposed to feel.”

Dr. Akhtar considered this carefully. “In view of everything you've just told me, I'd suggest the real question isn't 'stay or go' at all. It's whether you can hold both presence and distance without treating either as a betrayal of the other.” She paused. “Notwithstanding how difficult that sounds in principle, most people who manage it do so imperfectly — which is usually the only way anyone manages anything worth managing.”

For what it's worth, I would recommend that you not decide this in a single week, under pressure, with a deadline breathing down your neck.”

By the following Friday, Nusrat had accepted the offer, arranged for a cousin to move in for the year, and booked a ticket home for the winter break she had not, until then, been certain she would take. Her father, hearing the news, said only that it was essential the arrangement be reviewed honestly after the first term, rather than treated as settled the moment she boarded the flight.

It was not resolution, exactly — her mother's blood pressure remained what it was, her father's knees no better for any of this — but it was, Nusrat thought, an honest attempt at holding two true things at once: that she owed her family something real, and that she also owed herself a life she had not yet lived.

SECTION 3 | VOCABULARY ZONE

Instructions: This is the most extensive vocabulary list in the series. Study it in stages — perhaps ten words at a time — rather than all at once.

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
scholarship	noun	a financial award granted to support study	বৃত্তি
funding	noun	money provided for a particular purpose	অর্থায়ন
obligation	noun	a duty to do something, often moral or social	কর্তব্য / বাধ্যবাধকতা
filial	adjective	relating to the duties a child owes to a parent	সন্তানসুলভ (পিতামাতার প্রতি কর্তব্যসংক্রান্ত)
ambivalence	noun	the state of having mixed or contradictory feelings	দ্বিধাগ্রস্ততা
reconcile	verb	to make two seemingly opposed things compatible	সমন্বয় সাধন করা
autonomy	noun	the ability to make one's own independent decisions	স্বায়ত্তশাসন / আত্মনিয়ন্ত্রণ
deference	noun	respectful submission to another person's wishes	সম্মানসূচক বাধ্যতা
presumption	noun	an assumption taken to be true without proof	অনুমান
unspoken	adjective	understood without ever being directly stated	অনুচ্চারিত
resolve	noun/verb	firm determination; to settle a matter	দৃঢ় সংকল্প / সমাধান করা
clarity	noun	the quality of being clear and easy to understand	স্বচ্ছতা
betrayal	noun	the act of being disloyal to someone's trust	বিশ্বাসঘাতকতা
imperfectly	adverb	not perfectly; with some flaws remaining	অসম্পূর্ণভাবে

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
composure	noun	calmness and control over one's emotions	মানসিক স্থিরতা
undertaking	noun	a task or project that one formally commits to	গৃহীত দায়িত্ব / কার্যক্রম
warranted	adjective	justified or deserved under the circumstances	যুক্তিসঙ্গত / ন্যায্য
discretion	noun	the freedom to decide what should be done	বিচক্ষণতা / সিদ্ধান্ত গ্রহণের স্বাধীনতা
deliberate	adjective/verb	done consciously; to think carefully before deciding	সুচিন্তিত / চিন্তাভাবনা করা
contingent	adjective	dependent on something else happening first	শর্তসাপেক্ষ
presume	verb	to suppose that something is true without proof	অনুমান করা
subordinate	verb/adjective	to treat as less important than something else	অধস্তন করা / গৌণ করা
asymmetry	noun	a lack of equality or balance between things	অসমতা
hold something in tension	phrase	to accept two competing truths at once, without resolving them	দুটি বিপরীত সত্যকে একসাথে ধরে রাখা
weigh on someone's conscience	phrase	to cause someone persistent moral discomfort	বিবেকে ভার সৃষ্টি করা
come at a cost	phrase	to involve a real disadvantage or sacrifice	মূল্য দিয়ে অর্জিত হওয়া
breathing down someone's neck	phrase	putting someone under constant, close pressure	কারো ওপর ক্রমাগত চাপ প্রয়োগ করা
cancel each other out	phrase	to have opposite effects that neutralise one another	পরস্পরকে নিষ্ক্রিয় করে দেওয়া
for what it's worth	phrase	used to introduce an opinion offered modestly	যতটুকু মূল্য থাকুক (মেতামত প্রকাশে ব্যবহৃত)

Task A — Matching

Instructions: Match each word with its correct meaning. Write the letter in the Your Answer column.

Word	Your Answer
1. ambivalence	_____
2. deference	_____
3. autonomy	_____

Word	Your Answer
4. presumption	_____
5. discretion	_____
6. asymmetry	_____
7. reconcile	_____
8. warranted	_____
9. subordinate	_____

- A. the ability to make one's own independent decisions
- B. having mixed or contradictory feelings
- C. respectful submission to another's wishes
- D. an assumption taken to be true without proof
- E. the freedom to decide what should be done
- F. a lack of equality or balance between things
- G. to make two seemingly opposed things compatible
- H. justified or deserved under the circumstances
- I. to treat as less important than something else

Task B — Fill in the Blanks

Instructions: Choose the best word from the box and complete the sentences.

Word Box: obligation | composure | undertaking | contingent | deliberate | clarity | betrayal | resolve

- Nusrat felt a strong sense of _____ toward her ageing parents.
- Her mother managed to maintain her _____ even as she absorbed the news.
- Studying abroad on a scholarship is, in practice, a considerable _____.
- Her acceptance of the offer was _____ upon proper arrangements being made at home.
- Nusrat made a _____ decision to seek advice before committing to either path.
- Talking to her mentor gave Nusrat a measure of _____ she had lacked alone.
- She worried that leaving might feel, to her parents, like a kind of _____.
- By the end of the week, Nusrat's _____ to accept the offer had hardened.

Task C — Vocabulary & Structure in Context

Instructions: Read each quotation from the story and answer the analytical question about meaning or grammar.

- “What she could not yet bring herself to face was everything the message would set in motion.” What does this wh-cleft emphasise?

- “It was the thought of what leaving would actually mean... that undid me, not the flight or the paperwork.” What is being emphasised by this it-cleft, and what is being excluded?

- “Nusrat had never quite escaped the quiet, unspoken assumption that she would be the one who stayed.” What does unspoken suggest about how this expectation operated?

4. “It is important that this choice be yours.” Why is the subjunctive 'be' used here instead of 'is'?

5. “Provided that proper care is arranged for your father and me...” What relationship does 'provided that' establish between the two clauses?

6. “Notwithstanding how difficult that sounds in principle, most people who manage it do so imperfectly.” What contrast does 'notwithstanding' introduce?

Task D — Personal Vocabulary Journal

Instructions: Choose 5 new words or phrases from this episode. Write the Bangla meaning and your own English sentence.

No.	New Word/Phrase	বাংলা অর্থ	My Own English Sentence
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

SECTION 4 | GRAMMAR DETECTIVE — Clefts, Linking Devices & Subjunctive

Task A — Find from the Story

Instructions: Find and copy the required number of examples for each grammar focus from the story.

Grammar Focus	Examples from the Story
2 It-Clefts	_____
2 Wh-Clefts (What-Clefts)	_____
3 Advanced Linking Devices (whereas / notwithstanding / provided that / in view of / on the grounds that)	_____
3 Subjunctive Forms (that + base verb / be)	_____

Task B — Grammar Lab

Instructions: For each sentence, identify the structure, explain why it is used, and write a similar sentence of your own.

1. “It was her mother, not her father, who found her staring at the screen.”

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

2. “What struck me most... wasn't the scholarship at all.”

Which grammar structure is used? _____
Why is it used? _____
Write a similar sentence: _____

3. *"Whereas her brothers had left for work and marriage without a second thought ever being demanded of them..."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____
Why is it used? _____
Write a similar sentence: _____

4. *"Provided that proper care is arranged for your father and me... I see no reason ambition and duty must cancel each other out."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____
Why is it used? _____
Write a similar sentence: _____

5. *"It is important that this choice be yours."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____
Why is it used? _____
Write a similar sentence: _____

6. *"I would recommend that you not decide this in a single week."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____
Why is it used? _____
Write a similar sentence: _____

SECTION 5 | MIXED GRAMMAR CHALLENGE

A — Error Correction

Instructions: Each sentence contains one error in a cleft sentence, linking device, or subjunctive form. Rewrite it correctly.

1. It was her mother, not her father, that she confided in first — actually, both versions are used, but rewrite using 'who'.

2. What struck her most were how little her hesitation had to do with her parents' wishes.

3. Whereas her brothers left without question, however Nusrat felt a quiet obligation to stay.

4. Provided that care will be arranged, she agreed to accept the offer.

5. It is important that she stays for the right reasons.

6. Her mentor recommended that she doesn't rush the decision.

B — Multiple Choice

Instructions: Choose the best answer: A, B, C, or D.

1. It was her mother, not her father, _____ found her staring at the screen.
A. that B. who C. which D. whom Answer: _____
2. _____ struck her most was realising her hesitation was about expectation, not love.
A. It B. That C. What D. Which Answer: _____
3. _____ her brothers had left without question, Nusrat felt a quiet obligation to stay.
A. Despite B. Whereas C. Because D. Unless Answer: _____
4. _____ proper care is arranged, ambition and duty need not cancel each other out.
A. Provided that B. In spite of C. Even though D. As if Answer: _____
5. It is important that this choice _____ yours.
A. is B. was C. be D. being Answer: _____
6. Her mentor recommended that she _____ rush the decision.
A. doesn't B. didn't C. not D. won't Answer: _____

C — Gap Fill

Instructions: Complete each sentence with the correct form of the word in brackets.

1. It was the thought of leaving her parents _____ (undo) her composure, not the journey itself.
2. _____ (what) worried Nusrat most was her parents' unspoken expectation, not their actual words.
3. Whereas her brothers _____ (leave) without a second thought, Nusrat felt a quiet obligation to remain.
4. It is essential that the arrangement _____ (be) reviewed honestly after the first term.
5. Her father suggested that she _____ (consult) someone whose judgement she trusted.
6. In view of her mother's health, Nusrat _____ (decide) to visit every winter break.

D — Sentence Transformation

Instructions: Rewrite each sentence as directed, using the required grammar structure.

1. **Original:** Her mother, not her father, found her staring at the screen.

Rewrite as an it-cleft:

It _____ found her staring at the screen.

2. **Original:** Her hesitation, not the scholarship, struck her most.

Rewrite as a wh-cleft:

What _____ was her hesitation, not the scholarship.

3. **Original:** Her brothers left without question. Nusrat felt obligated to stay.

Combine using 'whereas':

_____, Nusrat felt obligated to stay.

4. **Original:** It's necessary. She should decide this herself.

Rewrite using the subjunctive:

It is necessary that _____.

SECTION 6 | SENTENCE BUILDER — Build Your Own Sentences

Instructions: Use each word or phrase to write one original sentence, following the required grammar structure exactly. Do not copy from the story.

Word / Phrase	Required Grammar Structure	Your Sentence
ambivalence	It-cleft	
autonomy	Wh-cleft (What...)	
deference	Linking device: whereas	
contingent	Linking device: provided that	
reconcile	Subjunctive (that + be)	
obligation	Subjunctive (that + base verb)	
asymmetry	Linking device: notwithstanding	
come at a cost	It-cleft	

SECTION 7 | SHORT WRITING TASK — Think & Write

Instructions: Write 150–200 words. Use at least one cleft sentence, one advanced linking device, and one subjunctive structure. Write down the main paragraphs only.

Prompt:

Some people believe that individuals should prioritise personal ambition and opportunity, even when this means significant distance from family for extended periods. Others believe that family responsibility should always take precedence over personal or professional advancement. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Writing Space

SECTION 8 | CHARACTER REFLECTION — Character Corner

Instructions: These questions have no single correct answer. Discuss with a partner if possible, then write your own considered response.

1. Nusrat's mother says, "I did not raise a daughter so that she could sit in this room, refusing a future out of guilt." What does this suggest about the difference between genuine filial duty and duty performed out of guilt or fear of judgement?

2. To what extent do you agree that family expectations placed on daughters and sons often differ, even within the same household? What might explain this asymmetry?

3. Dr. Akhtar suggests holding "presence and distance" together rather than choosing one completely. Is this a realistic way of managing competing obligations, or does it simply postpone a harder choice?

4. Nusrat's father asks that the arrangement "be reviewed honestly" rather than treated as permanently settled. What does this suggest about how family agreements might function over time, rather than as one-off decisions?

5. In many cultures and faith traditions, honouring one's parents is considered a serious and lifelong obligation. How might someone honour that obligation meaningfully while also pursuing significant opportunities far from home?

SECTION 9 | HOMEWORK

Level 1	Level 2
Write 6 sentences about balancing personal goals and family responsibility, each using a cleft sentence, an advanced linking device, or the subjunctive.	Write a reflective diary/essay entry (150–180 words) titled “A Decision Between What I Wanted and What Was Expected of Me.” Use at least 1 cleft sentence, 1 advanced linking device, and 1 subjunctive structure.

Final Reminder: Across this series, the hardest sentences to write well have rarely been about grammar alone — they have been about holding two true things at once. That, too, is a skill worth practising.